rights, power grids and fuel flows, and especially in the movement of people.

South Asia is undergoing a real transformation by encouraging win-win outcomes and buy-ins by partners. The Neighbourhood First outlook addresses this challenge in the immediate vicinity, just as parallel policies do in the extended neighbourhood. India's support to neighbours during the Covid period also reflected this very thinking.

Interdependence, however, has its own downside and can be leveraged unfairly when global norms are cast aside. Exposure to competitive polities, therefore, needs constant monitoring. We cannot always assume that all others will play by the rules. For that reason, as an interpreter of the world, diplomacy is also voice of caution. It informs a society of the risks and pitfalls even as it explains opportunities. Doing so in a systemic and organized manner is part of formulating strategy. By its very nature, foreign policy develops a comprehensive outlook and can guide other sectors. It could be trade and technology, or education and tourism. Current times, in particular, require a holistic approach to relationships.

ACCESSING A GLOBAL WORKPLACE

India may be blessed with an enormous human capital. But among the shortcomings is the inability to utilize that advantage to the fullest. Like many other aspects of life, that, too, is changing. National campaigns launched after 2014 are addressing a vast range of socio-economic challenges, ranging from gender discrimination and health to education, skills and employment. In this period, virtually every domain has seen a change due to progressive policymaking. Infrastructure growth, manufacturing expansion, smart cities and labour codes are among the notable examples. Our definition of basic necessities has changed to include access to water, power, housing and health. This has consequences not just for our national ambitions but also for global society.

At a time when demographic constraints are impacting the developed world, there is a real prospect of Indians gaining significantly in the global workplace. Till now, that has been self-driven, with policymakers largely agnostic on this happening. However, a conscious effort at bringing our human capital into play on the world stage can create a different set of outcomes.